Is

Relation Without Time, Cause, or Rule

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Abstract

One claim, made without machinery. To be is to stand in relation, and nothing further is required for there to be anything at all — no sequence, no cause, no rule about what may follow what. The companion accounts begin after this point and say so; this one supplies what they begin after. It is short because there is very little to say once the claim is stated, and that shortness is the argument.

1 The claim

What is, is. That is the whole of it, and everything below is an attempt to say what the sentence commits to and what it does not.

To be *something* rather than nothing at all is to be distinguishable, and to be distinguishable is to stand apart from something. *Distinction is relation.* There is no third option in which a thing is determinate and stands in no relation whatever: such a thing would differ from nothing, and a thing that differs from nothing is not a thing but the absence of one.

Proposition 1.1 (To be is to be related)**.** *Anything that exists as a determinate something stands in at least one relation. Equivalently: an existent bearing no relation is indistinguishable from non-existence, and the distinction between them is not available to be drawn.*

2 Which is to say: a graph

The claim has a name, and refusing to use it would be coy. Relata standing in relations are nodes standing in edges. *Everything is a graph* — and that sentence is the whole thesis of the companion accounts, stated here in the only form that requires nothing to state it.

The question this paper asks is the dumbest one available: *what is there?* A child can ask it and nothing prevents anyone answering. It is also the largest, because an answer to it constrains every answer to anything else, and because there is nowhere further back to stand. Asking it at that scope is the whole of the method: the shortest sufficient account of everything at once, which is what the companion on assessment calls minimum description length taken to its limit, and which lands here because at maximum scope the only structure shared by all of it is that it stands in relation.

Two things follow about the form of this paper. It has *no machinery*, deliberately: no transformation, no grammar, no economics, no frames, nothing that could be disputed in place of the claim. Whatever a reader disagrees with here, it is the claim itself, which is the condition a first paper should meet and which no later one in this programme does.

And the objection that arrives immediately can be answered in a line. *Everything can be represented as a graph, so the claim is empty* — yes to the first clause, and the answer is that

this is not a claim about representability. Nodes and edges are cheap; what is asserted is that there is *nothing else*, that relata and relations exhaust what there is, and that time and cause and rule in particular are not among the furniture. And the assertion is about *this* instance rather than about what is possible: a world with a global clock in its floor, or with production as a primitive, is not prohibited by anything here — such a world could be built and would be perfectly coherent — the claim is that *this one is not that.* What would bear on it is therefore a demonstration that this world has such a floor, which is an empirical matter and not a modal one, and imagining a world that does costs nothing and settles nothing.

That is also why finding one would bound the account rather than refute it, in the way a later theory bounds an earlier: the claim would hold of worlds without such a floor and this would not be one of them. The companions argue all of this at length; here it is a paragraph, because here there is nothing else to argue about.

3 One is not enough

A single relatum with nothing to relate to is not a minimal case of existence but a failed one. There is nothing for it to be distinguished from, so there is no fact about what it is; it does not sit at the bottom of the hierarchy of existing things, it fails to enter. *One relatum is decoherent.*

The empty case is the other end and is cleaner. Nothing at all stands in no relation, has no parts to be in tension, and admits no failure of fit — it is complete in the only sense available to it. That is why the empty set is the only perfect thing and why perfection is not something an existent can have: *to exist is to be imperfect*, because to exist is to be related, and to be related is to be partial with respect to what one is related to.

4 One direction only

A consequence of the restraint deserves its own statement, because it is what makes the claim's subject matter peculiar. *What merely is cannot observe; it can only be observed.*

To observe is to make a distinction, and making one is an act — something is done, and afterwards the observer holds what it did not hold before. That requires transformation and some grammar of what may follow what, and this paper has neither. So what is described here does nothing at all, and observing is among the things it does not do.

It can be the *object* of observation without difficulty, and in practice it is nothing else. A rock is what this looks like from outside: met, related to, distinguished by something that does have the machinery. But there is no corresponding inside. *There is no view from here* — not a narrow view, not a limited one, none — because a view is something a frame has and what merely is is not a frame. That is the floor beneath the familiar observation that no standpoint is perspectiveless: the only thing with no perspective at all is the thing that also cannot look.

Proposition 4.1 (Observation is one-directional at the base)**.** *What stands in relation without transformation or grammar can be observed and cannot observe. It is therefore always the object of a distinction and never the maker of one.*

5 What is not claimed

The claim above is smaller than it may appear, and the restraint is the point.

No time. Nothing here requires sequence. Relations hold; they do not happen. There is no earlier and no later in this paper, and no order in which anything is arrived at.

No cause. Nothing here makes anything else be. Relation is not production, and the account has no resources with which to say that one relatum brings about another.

No rule. Nothing here forbids anything or licenses anything. There is no admissibility, nothing that may or may not follow, and therefore nothing that could be violated.

Those three are not oversights and they are not deferred out of modesty. *They cost extra.* A world in which things also *happen* requires transformation and a grammar of what may follow what, and that is what the companion accounts introduce and pay for. This paper is what remains when they are removed, and it is offered as evidence that they are separable rather than constitutive.

6 Prior positions

None of this is new and it should not be dressed as though it were. That relations are prior to, or on a level with, their relata is the ontic structural realist position (Ladyman and Ross, 2007; Esfeld, 2004); that a thing is nothing over and above what it stands in is older than that and is stated more starkly elsewhere (Nāgārjuna, 1995); and the bundle tradition reaches a neighbouring conclusion by a different route (Williams, 1978).

What is contributed here is not the thesis but its *position*: that the thesis is enough on its own, that time and cause and rule are not required for it, and that an account of how things change can be built on top of it without folding any of the three back in. The companion papers are that account, and their first move is to assume this one.

7 Falsifiability

One commitment, and it is the only one this paper can carry.

1. [SHAPE] **To be is to be related.** A claim about this instance and not about every possible one. Fails on the exhibition of an extant something standing in no relation whatever — not merely one whose relations are unknown or unmeasured, which is the ordinary condition of most things, but one for which the claim that it stands in any relation at all is false. The burden is entirely on that side: no enumeration establishes the claim, since the domain does not terminate, and one instance would bound it.

One objection to that commitment has to be met, because an earlier version of this section raised it and was wrong. It runs: exhibiting a counterexample means observing it, observing relates it to the observer, so anything offered as unrelated is related by the act of being offered, and the falsifier cannot be met.

That slides from *relation* to *observation*, and the two are not the same. *Observation is not required for existence.* The tree falls in the empty forest and stands in relation throughout — to the ground it strikes, to the air it moves, to its own fibres as they part — and not one of those relations waits on anybody looking. Observation is a *kind* of relation, and a late and expensive one, since it requires a frame with the machinery to make a distinction; relation is the general case and requires nothing.

So the claim here is not that to be is to be perceived, which is a different thesis with a different name and is not held. What is claimed is that to be is to be *related*, and the falsifier asks for something standing in no relation whatever — not for something unobserved, of which there is a great deal. That makes the commitment harder to meet rather than easier, since a candidate cannot be rescued by pointing out that it is now related to whoever produced it: the question is whether it stood in any relation at all, and the fallen tree settles that without an observer anywhere.

Proposition 4.1 survives this unchanged. What merely is still cannot observe. It simply does not follow that it needs to be observed in order to be.

A second thing would count against the paper without falsifying the proposition, and is worth stating separately: if time, cause, or rule turned out not to be separable — if the account of change built on this one could not be constructed without folding one of them back into the base — then the restraint claimed in Section 3 would be a fiction and this paper would be an incomplete statement of the base rather than a minimal one.

References

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